Parishram 2.0 2026 (Class 12th)

The Last Lesson
Summary Notes

-Alphonse Daudet

Summary

Franz's fears while going to school

- late for school
- dreaded a scolding
- had not learnt his lesson on participles
- thought of running away and spending the day outside because:
  - the day was warm and bright with birds chirping
  - he was tempted to watch the Prussian soldiers drilling
- overcame temptations and hurried to school

Scene at the town hall

- a crowd in front of the bulletin-board
- it was source of all bad news: the lost battles, the draft, the orders of the commanding officer
- Franz worried what the matter could be
- astounded by the blacksmith's remark that there was plenty of timetoreach school

Usual scene at school

- began with a great bustle
- noise of opening and closing of desks
- lessons repeated loudly in unison
- teacher's ruler striking against the table hard

Changed scenario that day

- everything very still and as quiet as Sunday morning
- all classmates already in their places
- M. Hamel pacing up and down with the ruler under his arm
- Franz frightęned to enter

The classroom surprises Franz

- M. Hamel unexpectantly kind
- had put on his beautiful green coat, frilled shirt and an embroidered black silk cap which he normally wore only on inspection and prize days
- whole school wore a strange and serious look
- back benches strangely occupied by the village people

M Hamel's startling revelation

- M. Hamel demanded full attention and announced that it was their last lesson in French
- had received orders from Berlin to teach only German in schools of Alsace and Lorraine
- new teacher to join the next day

A grim realisation dawns on the narrator

- realised that he had so much more yet to learn
- felt sorry for whiling away his time and skipping his lessons
- now did not want to part with his books of grammar \& history, which he had earlier considered a nuisance
- deeply pained at the thought of M. Hamel going away
- forgot all about the teacher's ruler and his cranky nature
- realised that M. Hamel had worn his fine Sunday clothes in honour of the last lesson

A tribute by the villagers

- villagers gathered in the classroom:
- as a sign of,repentance for not having gone to school more often
- to thank their master for his meritorious service of forty years
- as a mark of respect for the country which was no longer theirs

Narrator's failure and the teacher's response

- Franz asked to recite the rule for participle
- wished that he was able to recite the rules flawlessly
- feels guilty on getting everything mixed up
- M. Hamel does not scold Franz
- comments upon man's nature of postponing things thinking there's plenty of time
- makes the audience realise the irony of being Frenchmen but not being able to speak or write their own language

Lack of learning: Hamel's view

- parents ignorant; not anxious to have their children leam
- children preferred to be put to work on farins or inills

- also blamed himself for sending children on errands for his convenience

M. Hamel teach - eulogises French language

- calls it the most beautiful language in the world
- asks the audience to always guard it and never forget it
- gives them their lesson ingrammar
- explains everything with unusual patience; probably wants to teach them everything in one go
- follows up witha lesson in writing
- gives new copies to the students with 'France Alsace' written in beautiful handwriting on them

Students exhibit rare attention

- everyone set to work very quietly
- there is a pin drop silence
- the only sound heard is the scratching of pens iover paper
- the little ones also work with concentration
- even beetles fail to distract them

Franz recalls M. Hamel's dedicated service

- Hamel had served the school for forty years
- nothing had changed: the garden outside the window and his class in front of him
- only the desks and the benches had worn smooth; the walnut trees grown taller and the hopvine planted by him twined about the window's to the roof

M. Hamel keeps his courage

- hears every lesson to the last
- delivers his last lesson in history
- everyone is roused to emotion when the lesson draws to its close
- tears roll down their eyes

M. Hamel rouses the spirit of patriotism

- as the church clock strikes twelve, trumpets of the Prussian soldiers sound under the windows
- overwhelmed with emotions, M. Hamel writes 'Vive La France' on the blackboard
- dismisses school by making a gesture with his hand

Answer the questions:

1. What was Franz expected to be prepared with for school that day?

2. Why was Franz tempted to play truant from school?

3. What was unusual about the school that Franz noticed when he entered the school?

4. What had been put up on the bulletin-board?

5. What changes did the order from Berlin cause in school that day?

6. How did Franz's feelings about M Hamel and school change?

7. What reasons did M Hamel give for their lack of interest in learning French?

8. Why doesn't M Hamel want the people to forget French?

9. Franz thinks, "Will they make them sing in German, even the pigeons?" What could this mean?

10. Describe how M Hamel conducted the last lesson.

11. What did M Hamel say about the French language?

12. Why did villagers come to school that day?

13. How did Franz find teaching and learning that day?

14. Give a brief description of M Hamel.

15. What is linguistic chauvinism? Is it possible to carry pride in one's language too far?

Hints and Solutions

1. Franz was expected to be prepared with participles that day for school, as Mr. Hamel had said that he would question them on participles.

2. The French teacher M Hamel was going to ask questions on participles which Franz had not prepared. To avoid being scolded he was tempted to play truant from school and spend the day out doors in a pleasurable manner.

3. On entering the school, Franz noticed that there was unusual silence. There was no noise of opening and closing of desks. The village elders had occupied the last benches that were always empty. M Hamel was in his very fine Sunday clothes. Everybody looked sad.

4. Franz had a negative view about the bulletin-board as for the last two years only bad news had come from it. That day was no exception as Germans had put up an order passed from Berlin on the bulletin-board to teach only German in the school of Alsace and Lorraine.

5. The order from Berlin caused man changes in the school that day. The entire school seemed strange and solemn. The old villagers were sitting on the back benches of the classroom quietly to thank M. Hamel for his forty years of faithful service and for showing their respect for the country. M Hamel also had put on his best dress on that day though it was not an inspection or prize day. The order from Berlin also brought a sense of repentance for those who in spite of having time didn't learn the French properly.

6. Earlier Franz didn't like M. Hamel much because of his ruler and cranky nature and he would feel fear from him but now all those feelings were entirely changed for M Hamel.
The message conveyed by M Hamel about the order from Berlin was a thunderclap for little Franz. He immediately felt sorry for not being sincere in the school and for not learning the French language and other lessons properly. His books, which seemed a nuisance and a burden earlier ere now Franz's old friends.

7. The lack of interest in learning French was due to the parents who wanted their children to work in farm or mill to earn, due to the students who were reluctant to learn and often put off the lesson for the next day. And due to himself as he asked them to water the flower and gave them off when he had to go for fishing.

8. M Hamel wanted them not to forget French as it is the most beautiful, clear and logical language in the world and as long as they hold fast to their language it would be as if they had the key to the prison.

9. The Frenchmen were highly patriotic and took a pride in their language. A strong feeling of revolt was in the air against the Germans. It shows that Franz did not accept their rule and thought that they can't tame pigeons.

10. In his last French class though M. Hamel was emotional he fully involved himself in the teaching learning process. He heard every lesson to the last sitting motionless in the chair. When the church bell struck twelve he stood up pale and wrote 'Vive La French' and with a gesture he communicated that the school is dismissed.

11. M Hamel said that French language was world's most beautiful, clearest and logical language and therefore it should be guarded and should not be forgotten by them. He also added that the love with one's own language can be proven as the key to the prison for the people who are enslaved.

12. The old men of the village came to the school that day to thank M Hamel for his forty years of faithful service. They also came to show their respect for the country that was theirs no more.

13. Franz found teaching and learning very interesting that day. He was very attentive and careful. Franz also realized that M Hamel had never explained everything with so much patience. It seemed almost as if the poor man wanted to give them all he knew before going away. M Hamel wanted to put it all into their heads at one stroke as it was their last lesson.

14. M Hamel was a very devoted, dedicated and a strict man of discipline. Students were afraid of his cranky nature and iron ruler. He was a true patriot and a sincere teacher who dedicatedly served the school for long forty years. The heart of this true Frenchman totally broke when he received the order from Berlin to vacate his place to make the space for a new German teacher. He remained upset during his last class. This changed his behavior too and he behaved rather very politely and patiently. When Franz was not able to say his lesson correctly, he, instead of scolding him, just made him understand about the importance and relevance of learning the mother tongue. He preached everyone presented in the class that important things should never be postponed as time flies very fast.

15. Linguistic chauvinism means an aggressive and unreasonable belief that your own language is better than all others. This shows an excessive or prejudiced support for one's own language. Sometimes pride in one's own language goes too far and the linguistic enthusiasts can be easily identified by their extreme zeal for the preservation and spread of their language. In their enthusiasm, love and support for their own language, they tend to forget that other languages too have their own merits, long history of art, culture and literature behind them. Instead of bringing unity and winning over others as friends, having excessive pride in one's own language creates ill-will and disintegration.

The stiff resistance to the acceptance of Hindi as national language by the southern states of India is a direct outcome of the fear of being dominated by Hindi enthusiasts. The result is that "one India" remains only a slogan.



PW Web/App - https://smart.link/7wwosivoicgd4

Library- https://smart.link/sdfez8ejd80if